heartland in south Karnataka's Old Mysuru region, where it has lacked a local leadership. Voters here have been divided between the JD(S) and Congress. For the BJP, which has struggled to get past the majority mark (113 out of 224 seats) in the assembly, the region is crucial. Its Hindutva pitch has won over the local Vokkaligas in the Malnad, coastal belts and in urban centres. "The emotional issue of religion has attracted people across communities; Vokkaligas are not an exception," says veteran Congress leader B.L. Shankar. But for rural Vokkaligas in the Old Mysuru region, the main issues are farm produce, the vagaries of nature and livelihood, he points out. The Kempegowda statue, he reckons, is unlikely to yield much for the BJP. "I don't think, politically, it will make an impact." The BJP's push in the Old Mysuru region comes via its Vokkaliga ministers such as C.N. Ashwath Narayan, R. Ashoka, K. Sudhakar and S.T. Somashekar.

Moreover, the JD(S) still enjoys the support of a substantial section of Vokkaligas without invoking Kempegowda. Its rivals are wary of the support Deve Gowda commands—in the 2018 Karnataka assembly polls, for instance, Vokkaliga votes consolidated in favour of the JD(S) because the Congress campaign led by Siddaramaiah was seen to be attacking the former PM. As Karnataka heads to the polls in about six months, the JD(S) is a key actor. Whether or not it results in a hung assembly will depend on its performance in the Vokkaliga bastion of south Karnataka.

"Do they think they will get votes if they come and offer flowers to the statue?" asked H.D. Kumaraswamy, Deve Gowda's son, last week, amid the row over the invite. On its part, the JD(S), led by Kumaraswamy, is preparing for a 'Pancha Rathna' rath yatra through the southern districts of Kolar, Chikkaballapura, Bengaluru Rural and Tumkur, starting from November 18. The plan is to reach the party's manifesto on education, employment, housing and health to voters. In next year's elections, the Vokkaliga heartland will be choosing between lofty symbolism and earthy issues. ■

BENGALURU/ KEMPEGOWDA INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

A Terminal of Grandeur

The Terminal 2 of Bengaluru's Kempegowda International Airport, inaugurated by PM Narendra Modi on Nov. 11, will begin operations in two months. With an indoor garden and state-of-the-art facilities, the terminal reflects all that Bengaluru stands for–a green, modern, innovative and culturally rich city. A peek into its key features:

Text by **AJAY SUKUMARAN** / Photograph by **JITHENDRA M.**

255,000
SQUARE METRES
The expanse of Terminal 2

₹5,000
CRORE
Cost of the project

25
MILLION
Annual passenger capacity



DEPARTURE IMMIGRATION

30 Conventional gates

10 e-gates

ARRIVAL IMMIGRATION

34 Conventional gates

6 e-gates

20 Visa-on-arrival counters

22 Contact gates

15 Bus gates

5,932 Gate lounge seating

9 Baggage claim devices